

Oman



Oman occupies a strategic position on the Arabian Peninsula, at the entrance to the Persian Gulf. It is the least developed Gulf state, despite modest oil exports.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly gravelly desert, with mountains in the north and south. Some narrow fertile coastal strips.



CLIMATE

Blistering heat in the west. Summer temperatures often climb above 113°F (45°C). Southern uplands receive rains June–September.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Urban drift has seen most Omanis move to northern towns. The majority are Ibadi Muslims who follow an appointed leader, the imam. Ibadism is not opposed to freedom for women, and a few women hold positions of authority. Baluchi from Pakistan are the largest group of foreign workers.



INSIGHT: *Until the late 1980s, Oman was closed to all but business or official visitors*



THE ECONOMY

Oil and natural gas account for almost all export revenue. Commercially extractable reserves are limited. Other exports include fish, animals, and dates. Foreigners work in all sectors.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Sultanate of Oman

DATE OF FORMATION: 1951

CAPITAL: Muscat

POPULATION: 2.85 million

TOTAL AREA: 82,031 sq. miles
(212,460 sq. km)

DENSITY: 35 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, Baluchi, other

RELIGIONS: Ibadi Muslim 75%, other Muslim and Hindu 25%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab 88%, Baluchi 4%, Persian 3%, Indian and Pakistani 3%, African 2%

GOVERNMENT: Monarchy

CURRENCY: Omani rial = 1000 baisa